

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Human rights

BEFORE

1866 America's first Civil Rights Act guarantees civil but not political and social rights.

1880s Jim Crow laws segregate the white and black populations in the Southern states.

1896 The Supreme Court allows segregation on the "separate but equal" principle.

AFTER

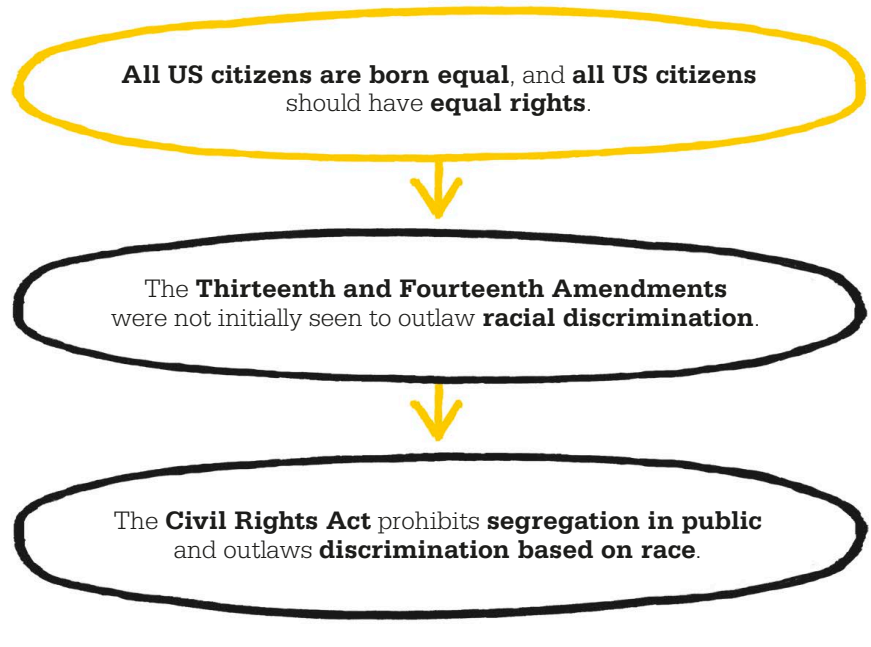
1965 The Voting Rights Act outlaws discriminatory obstacles that prevent black people from voting.

1968 The Fair Housing Act bans discrimination in housing.

2019 A white supremacist shooter in El Paso, Texas, kills 22 and injures 24.

In 1776, the US declared with forthright zeal in its Declaration of Independence, "We hold these truths to be self-evident, that all men are created equal" And yet this did not prevent black Africans from being kept as slaves for almost a century more. Even after the Civil War of 1861–1865 ended with slaves being given their freedom, black people continued to suffer. In the early 1960s, a century after the end of slavery, there was still racial segregation in the US.

In 1866, the first Civil Rights Act gave equal legal protection to all citizens. The Civil Rights Act of 1875 went further, affirming that



all people are equal in law and prohibiting racial discrimination in public places, such as on trains and in restaurants and lodging houses. However, five cases treated together in the Supreme Court in March 1883 nullified this, asserting that neither the Thirteenth Amendment to the US Constitution (which banned slavery) nor the Fourteenth (which guaranteed equal protection by the law) could prevent racial discrimination by private individuals and that this could not be prohibited by law. Essentially, the Court declared that the Civil Rights Act of 1875 was unconstitutional, which was a huge blow to the rights of African Americans.

Segregation

After the Civil War had ended, the Republican armies had protected the civil rights of freed slaves in the South, but in 1877, a political compromise withdrew those armies and gave Southern states "the right to deal with blacks without

northern interference." Named after a black caricature from American theater, the Jim Crow laws of the Southern United States came into force in the 1870s and 1880s and were every bit as racially divisive as South Africa's apartheid laws.

In theory, black people had the same rights under the Constitution as white people, but the Jim Crow laws gave racial segregation legal force. White and black Southerners

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It shall be unlawful for a negro and white person to play together ... in any game of cards or dice, dominoes or checkers.

Jim Crow law

Birmingham, Alabama, 1930

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